

SERMON - Level Design Document

Project Title: SERMON | **Genre:** Psychological Survival Horror (PSX-inspired)

Engine: Unity | **Platform:** Windows | **Playtime:** 15-20 minutes

Document Information

Level Designer: Kodali Chinmay Ram – Responsible for environment layout, pacing, player pathing, scare integration, and atmospheric tension through spatial design.

Key Collaborators:

Role	Name
Game Designer & Programmer	Vinil

Design Pillars:

- Isolation & Claustrophobia: Confined apartment spaces amplify dread.
- Subtle Build-Up: Notes and audio cues reveal lore without exposition dumps.
- Sleep Paralysis Mechanic: Immobility horror tied to real-life inspiration.
- Flashlight Dependency: Dynamic lighting controls visibility and vulnerability.

High-Level Overview

SERMON is a single-level experience set in a decaying, half-vacant three-floor apartment building. The player, desperate for cash, house-sits one night in a first-floor flat. As night deepens (in-game clock advances to ~3:00 AM), darkness engulfs the space, an unseen presence manifests, and psychological horror unfolds via exploration, note-reading, and escalating encounters. The level emphasizes **linear progression with branching exploration pockets** for replayability and tension relief.

- Core Loop:** Explore → Read Note (Lore/Tension) → Interact (Key/Object) → Trigger Event (Power Outage/Scare) → Escalate.
- Win Condition:** Survive the night (escape flat, but implied curse lingers).
- Fail States:** None.
- No Combat/Health**

Level Structure

The level is one seamless area: **"The Cursed Apartment"** (Ground Floor Flat + Upstairs Shared Bathroom). No hard loading screens; soft transitions via doors/hallways.

Key Areas & Flow

Area ID	Name	Description & Purpose	Size (Est.)	Access Trigger	Key Features
A1	Entrance Hall	Brief intro: Rusty door entry. Sets decay tone.	Small	Game Start	Note: Job instructions (voiceover).
A2	Main Flat Living/Kitchen	Core hub: Explore notes, daily objects. Builds normalcy.	Medium	Door from A1	Bodies, mirror (crawling entity), curse notes. Flashlight essential.
A3	Bedroom	Vulnerability zone: Attempt sleep → Paralysis.	Small	Open from A2	Bed (trigger),
A4	Hallway Corridor	Transition: Flickering lights, footsteps audio.	Linear	Doors from A2/A3	None
A5	Upstairs Bathroom	Horror climax: Gross, mirrored dread. Key hunt.	Medium	Stairs from A4 (postparalysis)	Opens the 2 nd Floor Flat Door
A6	Power Room	Restore light	Tiny	Turns on the Power	Lever (temp power), high scare density.

Player Path:

- A1 → A2 (Intro Exploration).
- A2 → A3/A4 (3:13 AM Power Out → Darken).
- A3 (Sleep Paralysis Scare: Immobile, entity appears).
- A4 → A5 (Flashlight hunt for Key).
- A5 → Escape Door (Entity Chase → Death/Escape).

Design Choice: Looping corridor (A4) prevents backtracking boredom; forces re-exposure to scares.
Tight doorways = chokepoints for chases.

Pacing & Tension Curve

Horror pacing: Slow build → Peaks → Release (false safety) → Climax.

Tension Table

Time (In-Game/Min)	Intensity	Events & Design Rationale
0-5 min	Low	Arrival, note-reading. Wide exploration teaches controls. Rationale: Establish normalcy/curiosity.
5-10 min	Medium	Power outage, footsteps (3 AM). Flashlight flickers. Rationale: Introduce vulnerability; audio guides path.
10-15 min	High	Paralysis, bathroom crawl. Entity visuals/audio. Rationale: Claustrophobia peaks in A5;
15-20 min	Peak	Chase/Escape.Rationale: Cathartic release via "escape," but note implies curse lingers.

Key Events & Scares

Event ID	Trigger	Scare Type	Player Impact	Level Design Integration
E1	Read 1st Note	Audio (Creak)	Footsteps hint.	Placed in high-traffic A2.
E2	3:13 AM	Environmental	Lights out → Flashlight only.	Clock prop in A3 enforces timing.
E3	Bed Interaction	Immobility	Paralysis: Entity looms.	Bed as dead-end; no escape visually.
E4	Bathroom	Visual/Jumpscare	Crawling shadow appears	Reflective surfaces amplify paranoia.
E5	Key Pickup	Chase	Entity pursues to door.	Long corridor (A4) maximizes pursuit tension.
E6	Escape	Psychological	"Cursed" note postescape.	Final room loops back to theme.

Flashlight Mechanics (Core to Level):

- Battery infinite, but flickers in "haunted" zones (A5).
- Reveals hidden notes/bodies subtly.
- Design: Player must manage aim for navigation + threat scanning

Audio & Visual Design

- Visual Style:** PSX low-poly, desaturated colors, rust/decay textures. Dynamic shadows via flashlight.

Audio Cues:

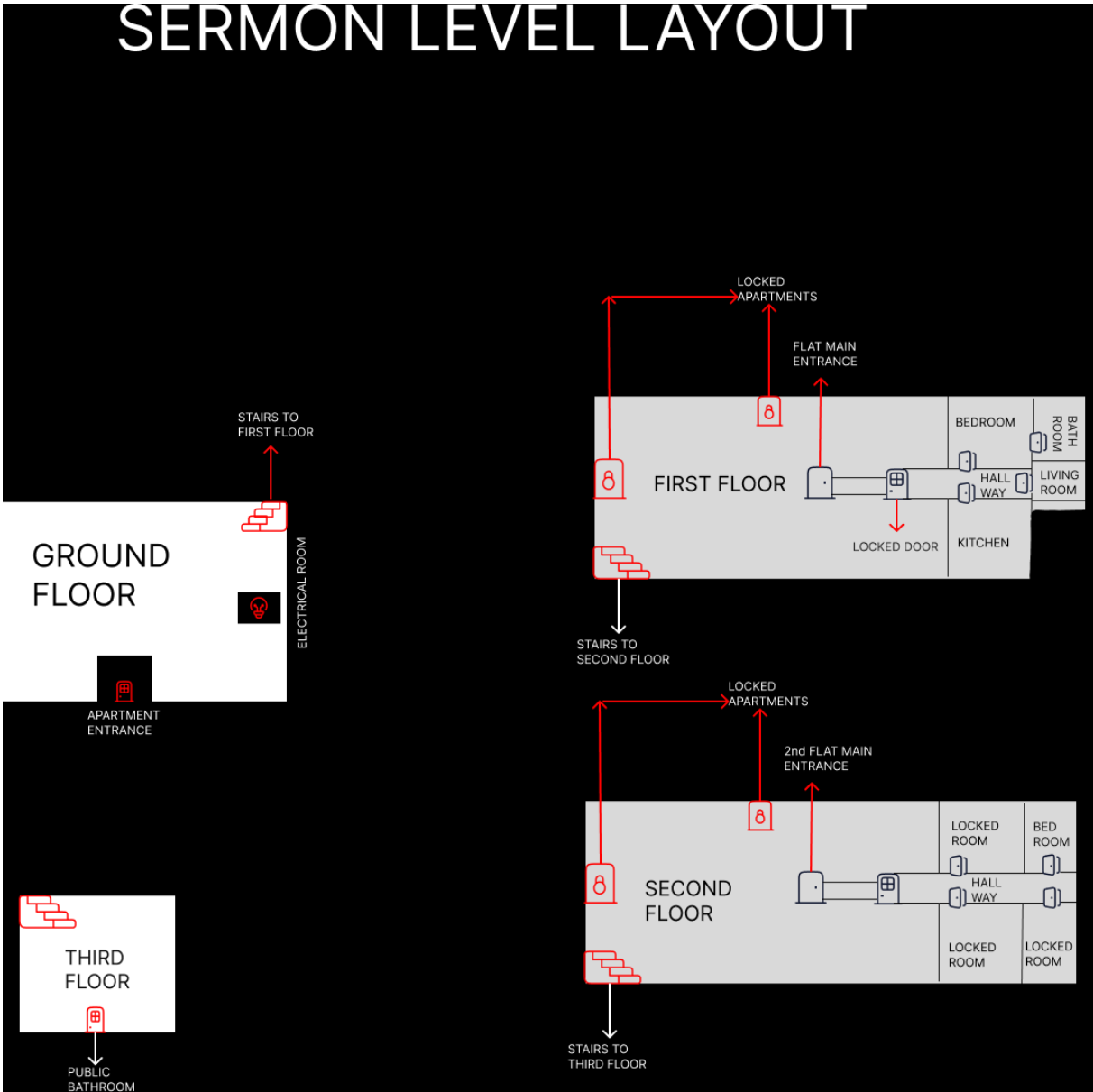
Cue Type	Example	Purpose
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Ambient	Distant breathing, ticks	Paranoia build.
Event	Footsteps (3 AM)	Directional threat.
Scare	Heartbeat during paralysis	Immersion in helplessness.

Lighting: 90% dark post-outage. Flashlight cone = player's "safety bubble."

Challenges & Iteration Notes

- **Player Pain Points Addressed:** Added key in obvious spot (boxes) to avoid frustration; looping paths prevent dead-ends.
- **Testing Insights:** 15min playtime tuned for mobile-like attention; scares tested for jump vs. dread balance (70% dread).
- **Future Expansions:** Unlockable Floor 3 for NG+ (cursed loops).



This LDD captures the level's focus on psychological immersion through spatial constraints and timed reveals. For implementation assets or Unity prefabs, reference shared drive. Contact Level Designer for revisions!